

career as a writer and his words on the subject remain still one of the best examinations of the problem in Italy. It would have been extremely stimulating to have had a fresh reappraisal of those concepts at the present time.

[C. L. G.]

CARDUCCI WITHOUT RHETORIC

February 16th of this year marked the fiftieth anniversary of Giosuè Carducci's death. More than perhaps any other modern Italian poet, Carducci needs critical revision and new focussing; the present anniversary may be a good occasion for that. His generally scarce reputation outside Italy is partly due to the fact that, like all poets who are supposed to deal mainly with patriotic themes, he looks like a strictly internal affair of his country; this situation dimly reflects his status in Italy as national bard (*vates*). Like political freedom, liberation from the critical impasse can be started only by forces within the country itself.

So far, the anniversary has brought one important contribution in that direction, Luigi Russo's *Carducci senza retorica* (Bari: Laterza, 1957). The "rhetorical" view which the book will help to supplant includes not only the *vates* notion but also the clichés of the optimistic nature-poet and of the officiating historical poet; the

twin rhetorical evils of *sanità* (wholesomeness) and *romanità* (Romanness) are debunked. The revision is conducted in many ways; various critical approaches are adopted (historical, linguistic); the book is hardly a systematic study of the poet's work and it rather reflects, like a good deal of contemporary Italian criticism, the temperament and manner of the particular critic. To choose one small illustration out of hundreds, Russo explains the unbelievable success of *Il bove* ("The Ox;" one of the most famous sonnets in the language, widely translated), partly in social terms, for it reflects a bourgeois or even *padronale* attitude toward rural life (p. 270); he finds the sonnet *A un asino* ("To an Ass") a much more congenial emblem for Carducci's real spirit, a better correlative for the poet's "be-grudged melancholy" (p. 325). Carducci's "historical" poems similarly seem to reflect the observer's melancholy and a solemn, rather than a triumphant and bellicose view of the country's past. Hence, Russo maintains, Carducci was misunderstood and misused, "his Rome was soon put aside, and another and more alluring one was moulded, to which Gabriele d'Annunzio contributed, and even Pascoli a little, and then all the politicians who have afflicted our existence in the last forty years." (p. 277).

[P. M. P.]

ITEMS

A "ROME THEATRE GROUP" has been established in Rome. The sponsoring committee is composed of Emilio Cecchi, Alberto Moravia, Mario Soldati, Leonida Repaci, C. Gordon Goldie, Amelita Stacy, Bernard Wall, and Mario Montesi. The "Rome Theatre Group" will be permanent and will present plays in English only. Its first season is to open with Shaw's *The Millionairess* with Dawn Addams in the leading role.

CASA EDITRICE SANSONI has undertaken the publication of *Ulisse* a review of international culture directed by Maria Luisa Astaldi.

LONGANESI AND CO. is preparing an edition in Italian translation of some of Damon Runyon's writings on New York. The volume will, of course, bear the title of *Bulli e pupe* (Guys and Dolls).

THE RESULTS OF THE VIAREGGIO literary competition, "Premio Viareggio," the most important annual compe-

tition in Italy, were as follows for 1956:

Narrative works: First prize of two million lire, *ex aequo*, to Gianna Manzini for the novel *La sparviera* ("The She-Hawk"), and to Carlo Levi for *Le parole sono pietre* ("Words Are Stones"). Honorable mention went to Enrico Emanuelli for his *Il quaderno Indiano* ("Indian Notebook"), to Marcello Venturi for his *Il treno degli Appennini* ("The Appennine Train"), and to Carlo Montella for his *Incendio al catasto* ("Fire at The Registry Office").

Poetry: First prize of a million lire to Giacomo Noventa for his volume of verse *Versi e poesie*. Honorable mention went to Camillo Sbarbaro for his *Rimanezze e fuochi fatui* ("Residues and Will-o'-the-Wisps"), to Sandro Penna for his *Una strana gioia di vivere* ("A Strange Joy in Living"), and to Giuseppe Villaroel for his *Quasi canto d'aprile* (Almost a Song of April).

Essays: First prize, *ex aequo*, to Nino Valeri for his *Da Giolitti a Mussolini* ("From Giolitti to Mussolini"), and to Giancarlo Vigorelli for his biography of the President of